

CRICKET CAMPS

Ranchi | JHARKHAND



The fields of dreams

Ready to shove aside big city softies, cricket-crazy young men from small town that gave M.S. Dhoni to the national team, hope with their hearts and play with their minds

■ By Sharda Ugra

Prakash Kumar Munda, 15, whippet-like, has seen paradise. It had grass. It covered a stadium in Jaipur and Munda never forgot. His usual patch of turf is Ranchi's multi-purpose Birsa Stadium. Patches of wispy tufts of grass can actually be sighted if it's not raining. Cricketers share the stadium with other athletes. Two strips of concrete and rudimentary netting in one corner make up the practice wickets and a small piece of surrounding earth with pebbles, dust and mud their field of dreams.

Coach Manik Ghosh has clippings of his cricketers who have played at the national level. Ankit Jalan, 19, has put his plans of becoming chartered accountant on hold to give cricket a go and takes pride in his rough training ground. "If we can make it from facilities like this, then we must have something. Players from the big cities tend to be complacent." Every afternoon in the off-season, Munda, Jalan and about 30 other boys train under Ghosh. There are, by a conservative estimate, at least seven cricket camps running in Ranchi where anything between 25 and 100 boys each are trained. The camps are run by former state players, coaches with certifications and without them, by anyone who might own

PITCH PERFECT: A practice session at Birsa Stadium

